

Capitalisation Rules

When to use capital letters, and when not to

Study guide for the University of Ibadan Postgraduate Test of English (EPT)

A capital letter tells the reader that a word is being used in a special way: it starts a sentence, or it names one particular person, place, thing or event. The EPT's mechanics section tests whether you use capitals exactly where they belong, and nowhere else.

Always capitalise

1 The first word of a sentence, and the pronoun /

✓ After the lecture, I went home.

After a colon, a capital is optional. Use it when what follows is a complete sentence you want to emphasise.

2 The first word of a quotation that is a full sentence

✓ She said, "We leave at noon."

✓ "If you are ready," he said, "we can go." *(the quotation continues, so no capital)*

3 Names of people, and titles used before a name

✓ Dr Adebayo, Professor Okafor, Chief Ojo, Aunt Bisi

✓ We met the professor. / My uncle is a lawyer. *(no name follows: small letter)*

A title used in place of a name when addressing someone is capitalised: "Thank you, Doctor."

4 Specific places

Countries, states, cities, streets, rivers, mountains, buildings and institutions:

✓ Ibadan, Oyo State, Awolowo Avenue, the River Niger, Olumo Rock, the University of Ibadan

✓ She studies at a university in the city. *(general words: small letters)*

5 Days, months, holidays, historical events and periods

✓ Monday, September, Christmas, Eid al-Fitr, Independence Day, the Nigerian Civil War

✗ This Summer / in the Rainy Season

Seasons are not capitalised: *summer, harmattan, the rainy season*.

6 Nationalities, languages, peoples and religions

✓ Nigerian, Yoruba, English, French, Christianity, Islam, Muslim, Christian

Words for God and names of deities in a specific faith take capitals: *God, Allah, the Almighty*.

7 Organisations, companies and brand names

✓ the Red Cross, the Nigerian Bar Association, Dangote cement, Peak milk

Capitalise the brand but not the general product that follows it.

8 Titles of books, articles, films and songs

Capitalise the first and last word and all important words. Articles (*a, an, the*), short prepositions (*of, in, on*) and conjunctions (*and, but*) stay small unless they come first.

✓ *Things Fall Apart, The Lion and the Jewel, A Man of the People*

9 Specific courses, and parts of a work followed by a number

✓ Biology 101, Chapter 6, Section 2, Volume III

✓ She is good at biology and economics. (*general subjects: small; but languages are always capitalised*)

10 Regions, but not directions

✓ She grew up in the North. / They live in the Middle East.

✓ Drive north for ten kilometres. / Rain came from the west.

11 Letters: salutation and closing

✓ Dear Sir, ... Yours faithfully,

✓ Dear Mr Okon, ... Yours sincerely,

Capitalise every word of the salutation, but only the first word of the closing.

12 Official titles with a specific holder or office

✓ the Vice-Chancellor of the University; the President of Nigeria

NOTE

Institutions vary in how they write their own titles (for example *Vice-Chancellor* or *Vice Chancellor*). Follow the form used by the institution concerned. The key rule is that a specific office is capitalised, while a general use is not: *several vice-chancellors attended*.

Do not capitalise

Type of word	Written as
Seasons	summer, winter, harmattan
Directions	north, south-west, eastward
General subjects of study	history, chemistry, law (but English, French)
Titles after <i>my / our / the</i> with no name	my doctor, our lecturer, the judge
Diseases (unless named after a person)	malaria, measles, cancer (but Parkinson's disease)
Plants, trees and animals	mango, iroko, hibiscus
General nouns for places	the city, the university, a high school

EXAM TIP

In the EPT, most capitalisation options differ by only one or two letters. Read each option word by word and ask: is this the name of one particular thing, or a general word?

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